MISSOURI

The Show-Me State



In the German immigrant bakeries lining the neighborhoods of South St. Louis in the early 1940s, mistakes were not taken lightly. Bakers who had crossed the Atlantic carrying generations of craft—the precise ratios, the patient rises, the exacting standards of the old country—ran their shops with quiet pride along streets like Cherokee and Gravois, where the smell of yeast and butter drifted through screen doors from before dawn.

The story most often told is a simple one: a St. Louis baker, believed by many food historians to be from the Heimburger Bakery, accidentally reversed the ratio of butter and flour in a coffee cake recipe. Instead of a light, structured crumb, what came out of the oven was dense, sticky, and almost custardy at the center—a golden, gooey layer beneath a thin sugared crust that crackled at the touch. By any technical measure, it was a failure. He sold it anyway, likely because wasting ingredients during the lean wartime years was simply not an option.

His customers came back for more.

What spread through St. Louis in the years that followed was nothing short of a quiet obsession. Neighborhood bakeries across the city—many of them still run by German and Czech immigrant families who had settled in the tightly knit communities of Soulard, Bevo Mill, and Dutchtown—began making their own versions. It appeared at church potlucks and family gatherings, on diner counters and holiday tables, always in a sheet pan, always cut into squares, always slightly warm and better than it had any right to be. No fork required. That was the unspoken rule.

By the time St. Louis began defining itself as a food city, Gooey Butter Cake was already its most honest signature—not sophisticated, not refined, just deeply satisfying in the way that only accidental genius can be. It asked nothing of the baker except attention and a willingness to pull it from the oven before it looked quite done, trusting that the center would set into something magnificent as it cooled.

That trust is well earned. Once you make this, you will understand immediately why St. Louis never let it go. The edges are firm and golden, the center yields like a warm custard, and the powdered sugar on top dissolves on your tongue before you've even decided to take a second piece—which you will, without question. This is the rare dish that feels like both comfort and indulgence at once, a pan of something that disappears faster than you expect and leaves everyone in the room a little happier than before.

St. Louis got it wrong once. Lucky for all of us, they never bothered to correct it.

GOOEY BUTTER CAKE

One bite of St. Louis's legendary Gooey Butter Cake—its crisp edges giving way to a molten, buttery center—and you'll understand why no one in Missouri ever needs dessert to be anything more.

Yield: 12–16 servings

INGREDIENTS

BUTTERY BASE CAKE

- 1 (15.25–16.5 oz.) box yellow cake mix
- 8 Tbsp (1 stick) unsalted butter, browned and slightly cooled
- 1 large egg
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ¼ tsp salt

GOOEY CREAM CHEESE TOP

- 1 (8 oz.) package full-fat cream cheese, softened
- 2 large eggs, at room temperature
- 1 large egg yolk (for extra custardy body)
- 8 Tbsp (1 stick) unsalted butter, browned and slightly cooled
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- ¼ tsp salt
- 4 cups (1 lb.) powdered sugar, plus more for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the Pan and Oven*: Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Generously butter or spray a 9×13-inch baking pan, then line it with a parchment sling for easy lifting. This is a soft, gooey cake, so a well-greased or lined pan is what lets you get clean squares out later.
2. *Brown the Butter for the Base*: In a saucepan over medium heat, melt the stick of butter for the base and keep cooking, swirling, until it foams and turns golden with a nutty aroma and browned flecks, 3–5 minutes. Watch closely at the end—it turns from browned to burnt fast. Pour it into a bowl (scraping in the browned bits) and let it cool a few minutes. Browning the butter is what earns this a real "butter cake" flavor instead of the flat sweetness of the box versions.
3. *Make the Base Layer*: In a large bowl, mix the cake mix, browned butter, 1 egg, vanilla, and salt by hand until a thick, uniform dough forms. Do not prepare the cake mix per the box directions—this is meant to be a dense, cookie-like crust, not a fluffy cake. Press the dough firmly and evenly into the bottom of the prepared pan, pushing it slightly up the sides.
4. *Beat the Cream Cheese Smooth*: In a separate large bowl, beat the softened cream cheese alone with a mixer on medium until completely smooth and lump-free. Don't rush this step—starting with lump-free cream cheese is the single biggest key to a silky gooey top. Cold or under-beaten cream cheese will leave stubborn lumps you can't fix later.

5. *Build the Gooey Layer*: Turn the mixer to low and add the 2 eggs and the egg yolk one at a time, mixing just until each is incorporated. Beat in the melted butter, vanilla, and salt. Add the powdered sugar about a cup at a time on low speed, mixing just until smooth and scraping down the bowl as needed. The extra yolk and the pinch of salt give this top a richer, custardy body and keep it from being cloyingly sweet.
6. *Assemble*: Pour the cream cheese mixture evenly over the base layer and gently spread to the edges. Do not swirl or mix the two layers together—the magic of this cake is the distinct buttery crust on the bottom and the gooey layer on top.
7. *Bake to the Perfect Jiggle*: Bake for 40–45 minutes, until the edges are golden brown and set but the center still has a distinct jiggle when you gently shake the pan. This is the most important step: the biggest mistake is overbaking. The center should look underdone—it will finish setting as it cools, and that's exactly what gives you the signature gooey texture. If the edges brown too fast, tent loosely with foil.
8. *Cool, Dust, and Serve*: Let the cake cool completely in the pan on a wire rack, at least 1–2 hours, so the gooey layer sets. Dust generously with powdered sugar, then lift out using the parchment and cut into squares. Serve slightly warm for maximum ooey-gooeyness, at room temperature, or chilled for a firmer, more custardy bite. Store leftovers covered in the fridge.

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Gooey Butter Cake — finished dish illustration

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people